



50 |

“There are other business houses which have been absolutely exciting to work with... but I would still say that if I have a fondness for one group, it would be the House of Tata”

Q: And what he may or may not have told you was that all these judges who had lunch together, were mostly men. There could be no doubt that you were entering a male bastion. What was it like? Would you tell a young woman who is considering law as a profession today that things are vastly different than when you got into this profession?

A: So it's in two buckets, Udayan. Today, if you're a practising counsellor or a barrister, as a woman, even after so many decades, I will say it is still extremely tough. I'm not sure I can put my finger on it, other than to say that it's a difficult world to break into. And, as a woman, it absolutely requires extra time and commitment to show that you are as good as your peer who is a male.

I remember when I was a young barrister, I would always work 30 per cent more than my male

counterpart because I was capital P for paranoia. I couldn't afford to make a single mistake in court, because I was so conscious that I was probably the only woman who was arguing that matter on that day. So as arguing counsel, still not good at all. I think we have a long way to go. It is very hard to be dancing and prancing and acting day after day for eight hours, preparing for another five hours at night for the next day, and having to multitask as a woman without the essential social infrastructure and ecosystem.

As a corporate lawyer or as a non-litigating lawyer, it has become much easier for women. Not terribly easy, but much easier. And that is simply because in today's world, everybody needs talent. And if they need talent, then women are talent. So, you can't afford to just let any bright woman drop off the landscape and fade away from the firm without making that effort to retain that incredible source of talent. So, it is getting better for sure on that front.

Q: You've been at the forefront of many of these recent PE deals like the SoftBank-Ola deal, which have created such a large number of unicorns. What do you make of this trend? I was speaking to your friend Ronnie Screwvala, who said PE can become an end in itself. Would you sound a word of caution as well, given the kind of valuations that are being drummed up by PE infusion in India today?

A: You can't have it both ways, right? You can't say I want these incredible valuations but not welcome the person who is going to give them to you. So, it is the mix between where the promoter wants to